

How to Go Digital in American Literary Studies

A beginner-centered DH course

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This class is designed for students (and a teacher) who are entirely new to Digital Humanities.

Students who have been hesitant or reluctant to use digital methods in their studies—myself included—are especially welcome.

Course context

An undergraduate American literature course primarily for English majors with little or no CS or DH background.

Each week, the class reads one short story, including Brown's "Somnambulism," Sedgwick's "Cacoethes Scribendi," Poe's "The Man of the Crowd," etc.

A typical class session

Each class session typically combines close reading, shared annotation on Google Docs, and a short hands-on experiment with a digital tool.

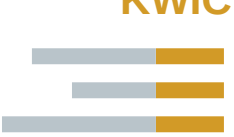
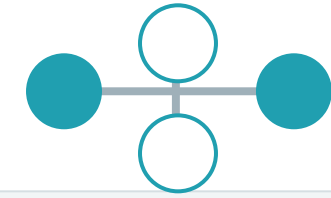
All primary texts are shared through Google Documents. Students add comments throughout the semester.

What counted as success

The main goal of this course—whether you like it or not—is to DO SOMETHING with digital tools.

The course values process over results, and even failed experiments or messy outputs are treated as meaningful outcomes.

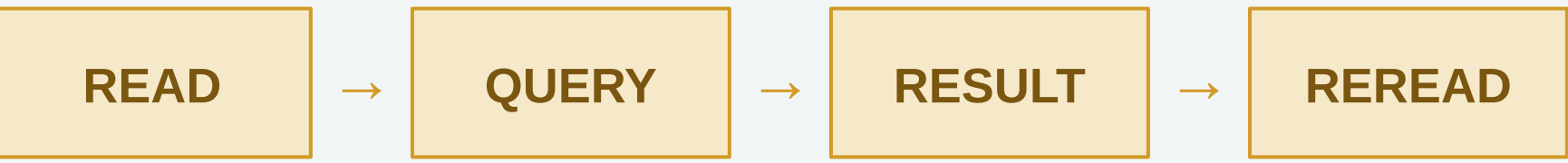
The course progressed through three layers

LAYER 1 FREQUENCY & CONTEXT	 KWIC	METHODS Frequency · KWIC · distribution · repetition	READING MOVE Verify patterns in the text.
LAYER 2 WORDS IN RELATION	 N-grams	METHODS N-grams · co-occurrence · vectors · HistWords	READING MOVE Use nearby words to reread.
LAYER 3 CONTEXTUAL SEARCH	 SBERT	METHODS Keyword · SBERT · compare methods	READING MOVE Compare what models reveal—and miss.

Twelve short stories provide common ground. Full schedule and handouts via QR.

Make the process visible

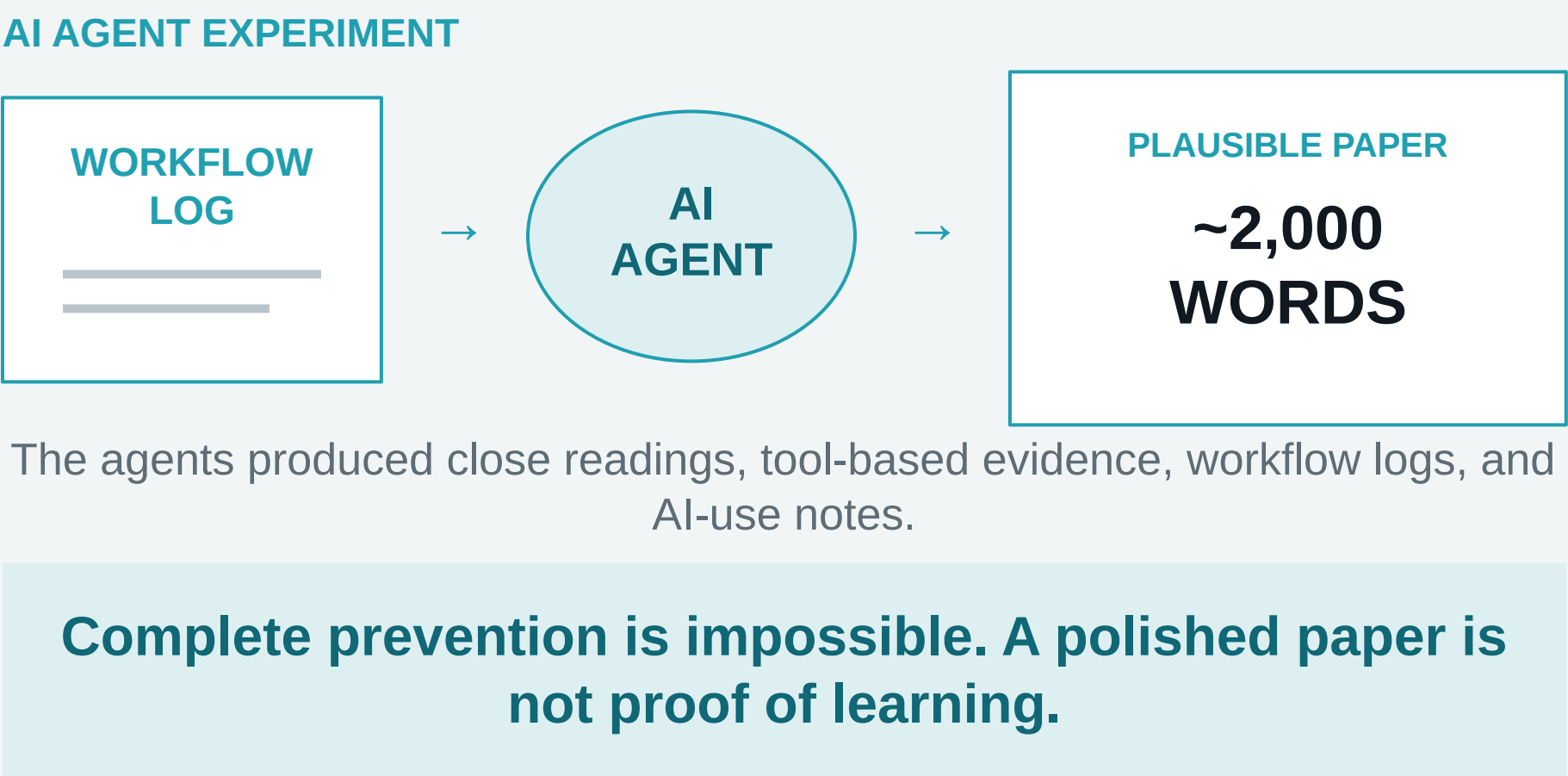
The workflow—not just the paper—shows learning.



Students record the text, tool, query, result, and passage reread. AI use is disclosed separately.

Criterion: Does the log make the learning process visible?

Test the limit



Full papers available via QR code.

The teacher is learning too

LLM Math Tutor—Learning with an AI Agent



Goal: read equations in Attention, BERT, and GPT papers. Day 1: notation, vectors, and matrix shape.

Teacher learning is part of course design.

What students did every week

1 BEFORE CLASS

Read the assigned text in Google Docs.
When scheduled, prepare an individual presentation using a digital method.

2 IN CLASS

Add and share two comments.
Run a small experiment on a passage, word, or pattern.
Return to the text and write a short memo.

3 EXPERIMENT MEMO

What did you try?
What did you notice?
What did not work?
What do you want to try next?

I would welcome your feedback

How much technical support do students need?

What would make this course reusable for non-DH instructors?

What concerns would arise in your own classroom?

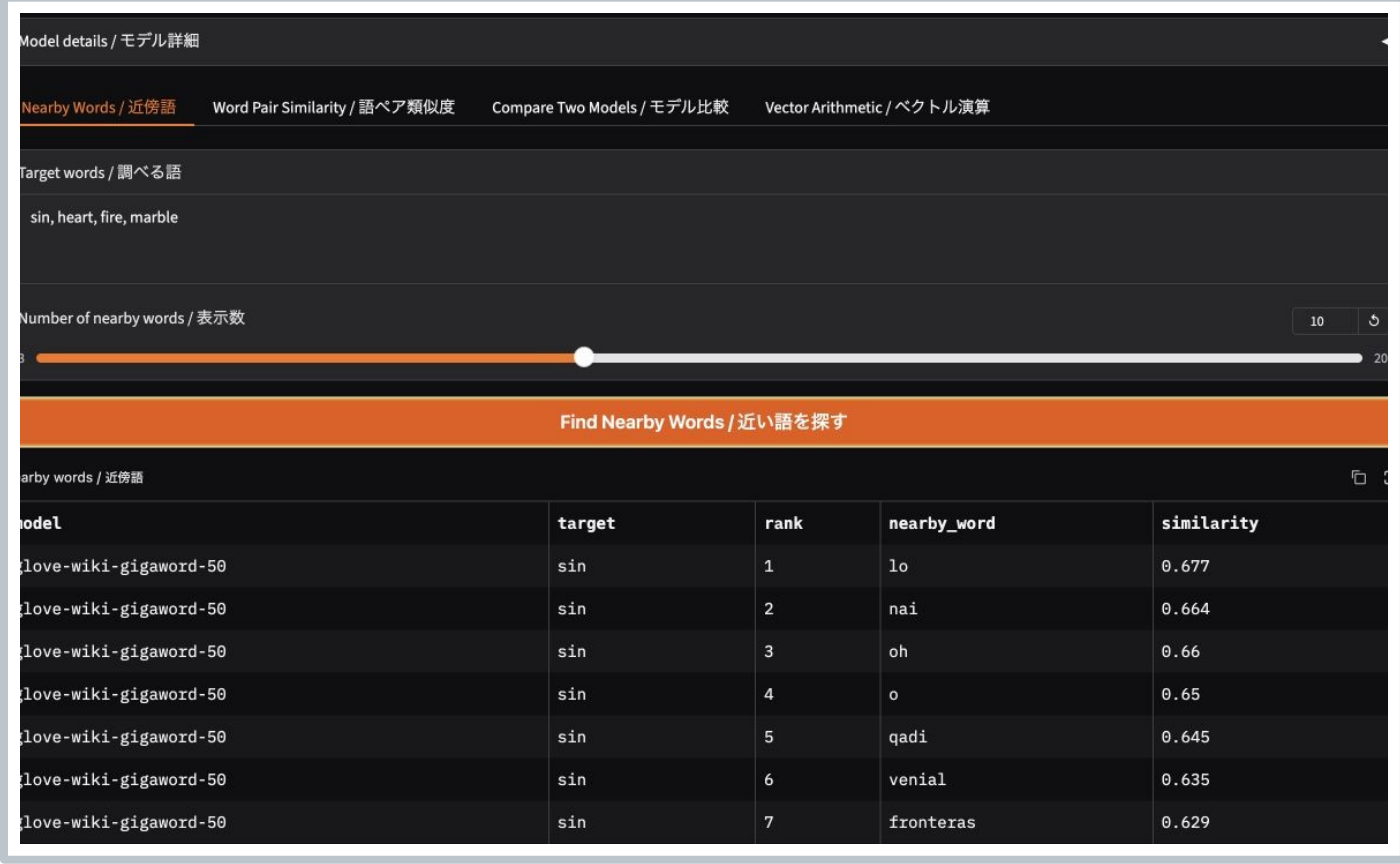


Tools actually used in the course



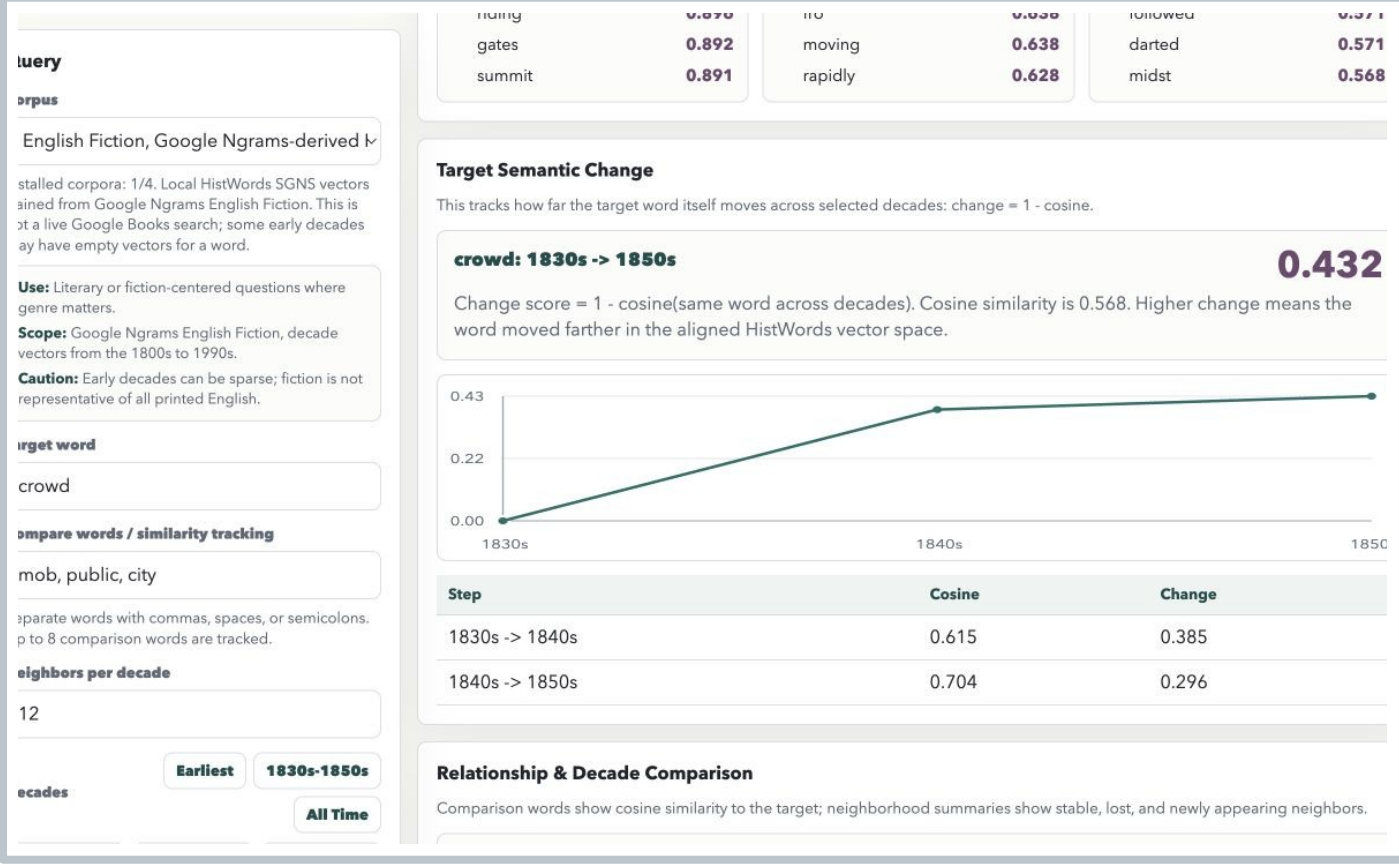
DH Reading Lab

Frequency, KWIC, distribution, and repetition - always followed by a return to the passage.



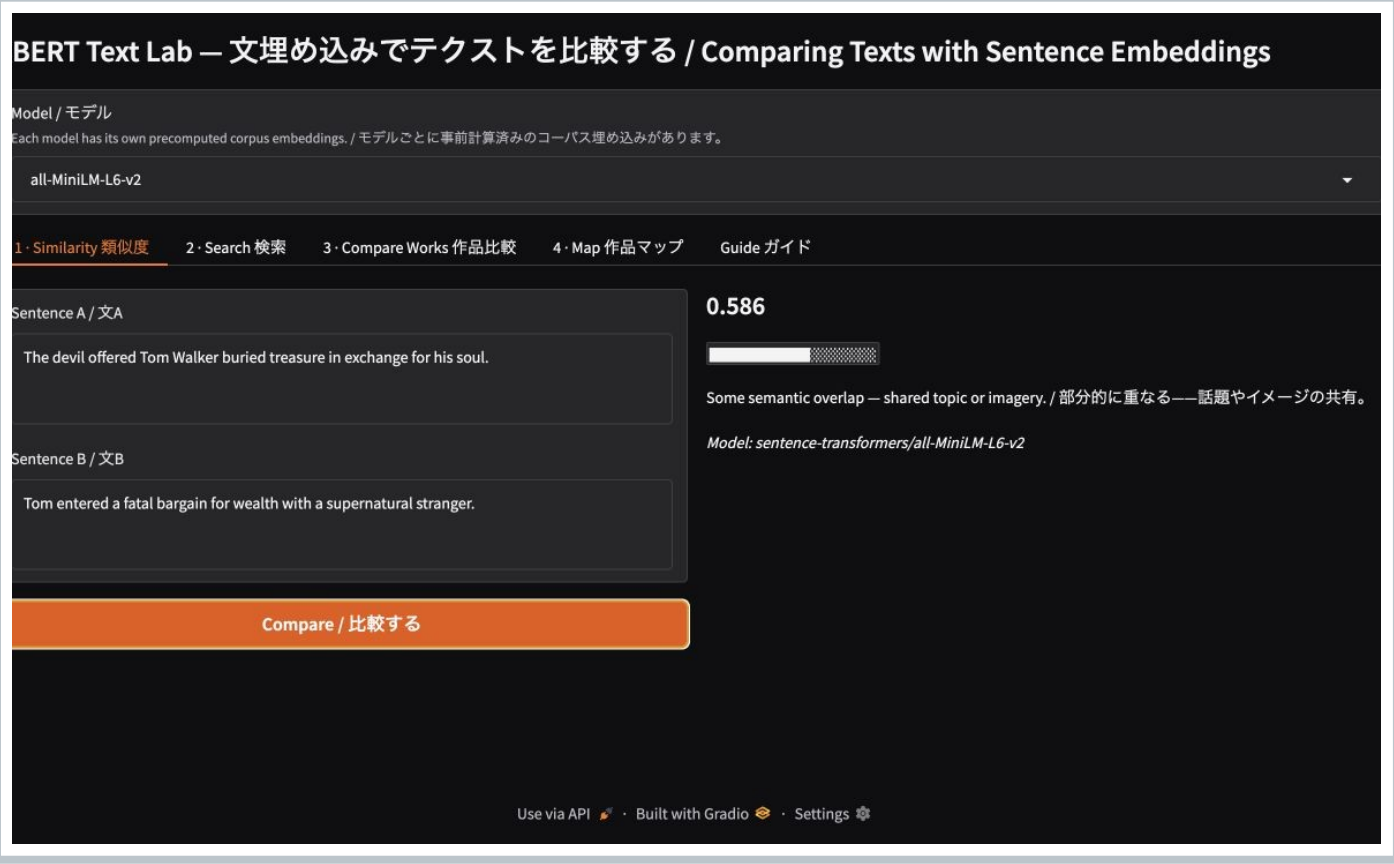
Word Vector Explorer

Nearby words become prompts for noticing agreement, mismatch, and new questions.



HistWords Explorer

Decade-level neighborhoods show change over time and generate historical questions for rereading.



SBERT Text Lab

Keyword search finds strings; semantic search finds contextual proximity. Both lead back to the text.

HistWords: Hamilton, Leskovec & Jurafsky (2016).

No Coding Skills. No Advanced Math. No Control over AI. What Can Humanities Teachers and Students Do?